

REVENGE OF THE LITTLE PEOPLE

In the age of economic anxiety, an expanding universe of TV and big screen audiences rejected sham. Larger-than-life heroes were out and straight-from-the-heart stories were in.

By Kaveree Bamzai

Being an entertainer wasn't easy in the year of the shrinking rupee. Forget the swagger and the wink that kept our stars afloat in the money-rich years of 2007 and 2008. Think instead of Aamir Khan's slouch as Rancho in *3 Idiots* and Ranbir Kapoor's wide-eyed wonder as Prem in *Ajab Prem ki Ghazab Kahani*. Two of the biggest hits of the year starred two of its sweetest innocents. All that Rancho, the son of a gardener, wanted was to study, whether it was by borrowing his rich master's uniform or his identity. All that Prem, Class VII dropout and president of the no-name town's Happy Club, wanted was to get on the front page of the newspaper. It was no different on tv. Whether it was Rakhi Sawant's dramatic groom hunt on *Rakhi ka Swayamvar* which singlehandedly made NDTV Imagine worth

a 92 per cent stake for Turner or Vindu's desperate desire to be the next *Bigg Boss* which got him Rs 1 crore, audiences rewarded persistence, whichever way it was packaged.

It helped if something was first off the mark. The first time *New York* tried terrorism, audiences flocked to watch John Abraham stretching his newly found acting muscles. The second time *Kurbaan* tried to repeat the terror-in-the-city theme, it fell flat. Equally, it helped if the audience outside the metros got a chance to see a tiny sliver of itself—check *Agle Janam Mohe Bitiya Kijo* where Laali was sold to provide an heir to a rich Thakur. But most of all, it helped if audiences sensed something was straight from the heart, albeit enhanced by a few psychotropic substances, as in Anurag Kashyap's uninhibited *Dev.D*. It was the year of the slacker boy and the champion girl. Imperfect

heroes abounded, having lost their six packs and shed their eight packs. In their place were men such as Devender Singh Dhillon from *Dev.D* who was famously declared as being hairy by his raunchy girlfriend and boys such as Siddharth Mehra from *Wake Up Sid* who learnt the art of frying the perfect egg from the girl next-door. The men abdicated their responsibility to make the first move or even establish relationships. Girls took the lead instead. In Vishal Bharadwaj's *Kaminey*, it was Sweetie who took the initiative to make Guddu a man while organising the wedding and booking the honeymoon on *make-mytrip.com* and in *Love Aaj Kal*, Saif Ali Khan's Jai had to move from London to San Francisco to realise he'd left his heart behind in Delhi with his sometime fresco artist girlfriend.

